



SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE

MONEY TALKS

Homai Ardeshir Daruwala

59, Banker

Despite your qualifications, at the end of the day, we prefer a man to a woman." That is what Mumbai-based H.A. Daruwala was told by corporates when she wanted to start her career as a chartered accountant in 1974. It made her change tracks and she joined the Union Bank of India as a probationary officer. Three decades later, she is the CMD of the Central Bank of India that has more than 25 million account holders. "I wanted the cabin and the respect. I wanted to be a part of the power circles. The money wasn't bad either," she says. She's got all four now, commanding the work of 3,308 branches of the 97-year-old bank. "I won't pretend it has been easy. I was the only woman officer in my department and there were men who didn't like answering to a woman boss. I've bruised a few egos on the way up but it's something you learn to deal with," she says. Daruwala is now aiming to make the bank a one-stop shop for all banking needs, with every branch offering core banking facilities that allow customers to operate their accounts from anywhere in the country, through the Internet and mobile phones.

FIRST INVESTMENT 50 shares of Reliance Industries for Rs 10 each. They gave me good returns and I sold them in 1985 to go on my first vacation abroad, Abu Dhabi.

WORST INVESTMENT DECISION AND THE LESSON LEARNT I invested Rs 2,500 in a fixed deposit on a colleague's advice early in my career. It went down the drain. It has made me do my own homework and trust my judgement instead of going on hearsay.

PROPERTY WATCH A flat near Sion in Mumbai, which I bought in 2003. Its value has appreciated 700 times and I'm planning to sell it and buy a bigger flat closer to where my family lives, in Dadar.

BIGGEST INDULGENCE I love to pamper myself and buy diamond jewellery during the festive season. Crystal is another weakness.

USE
THIS
TIP

"BUILD A MIXED PORTFOLIO, KEEP TABS ON HOW YOUR INVESTMENTS ARE FARING AND MAKE DECISIONS ACCORDINGLY."